

*Mujhe Bachao.* As women grew up overnight, boys refused to become men, whether it was on UTV Bindass' offensive *Sid Vs Varun*, where humiliations varied from eating a sandwich formerly placed in the armpit to drinking coffee boiled with used underwear, or *3 Idiots*, where much hilarity ensued when the boys peed on their principal's nameplate or crashed his daughter's wedding. As Harpreet 'Rocket' Singh would say, "Risk to Spiderman ko bhi lena padta hai". From MTV's *Splitsvilla* where boys were auctioned to NDTV Imagine's *Raaz Pichle Janam Ka* where past lives were excavated, everyone pushed the boundaries.

The all-too-smug superstar took a backseat as big budget porn sank

so did they on the big screen, with movies such as *Wanted* and *Ajab Prem ki Ghazab Kahani* making 55 per cent of their revenue from single screens as opposed to 65 per cent from multiplexes and *3 Idiots* topping the screen count at 2,150 with greater digitisation. Perhaps it was the strike which halted Bollywood's conveyor belt predictability, giving audiences a two-month pause to get used to a life with just the simulated outrage of election-infused television news and the exuberant cheerleading of the tamasha-obsessed IPL. As the number of TV viewers went up to 187 million from 170 million in 2008, taking penetration to 85 per cent, the number of channels rose from 389 to 417 in a year as Hindi-



**Fabloid Couples** They sold glossies and TV specials but not movies. After *Tashan*, Saif and Kareena fizzed out in *Kurbaan*. Even a Shiv Sena protest didn't save them.

**Pricey Actors** Big pay packets had to be justified by big openings. They weren't always. Ask Salman Khan and Akshay Kumar.

**Star Directors** Ashutosh Gowariker made a rom com at epic length. Rakeysh Mehra tried to show how the evil was in all of us in *Delhi-6*. Out, said the audience.



**Sony's re-vamp** Well before it hitched its wagon to YRF's falling star, Sony launched new shows such as *Ladies Special* and *Bhaskar Bharti*, but remained stubbornly at fourth place with 179 GRPs.

**Music Shows** TV made music muqablas bigger but according to TAM, non-fiction shows saw a dip.

**Ekta Kapoor** With *Bairi Piya*, she officially became a follower of lesser-known production houses such as Rajan Shahi's Director's Kut of *Bidaai* and *Yeh Rishta Kya Kehlata Hai* fame.

under the weight of its own hype, which would explain why Akshay Kumar's sexist, racist Sethji took a bigger dive than the sharks in *Blue* and why the Denise Richards-wooing stuntman got a thumbs down in *Kambakht Ishq*. Audiences wanted it to be kept simple, but not stupid. From being a factory manufacturing *gadhas* (donkeys) it wanted Bollywood to become an instrument of enlightenment. As audiences expanded on the small screen, going to smaller towns,

speaking markets saw a 4 per cent rise in prime time viewership.

What of the first year of the next decade? As TV waited for digitisation, wondering what the next big thing would be, IPTV or 3G, Bollywood wondered how to make not just the best possible movie but also at the best possible price for the best possible audience. Because as Rocket Singh would say, business, even showbusiness, is not about numbers. It's about people. Especially the little people. ■

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